

Psalms 135

Praise the Name of the Lord

Praise the Lord; for the Lord is good: sing praises unto his name; for it is pleasant

KJV · Standalone study handout

1 · THE WORD (KJV)

- 1 Praise ye the LORD. Praise ye the name of the LORD; praise him, O ye servants of the LORD.
- 2 Ye that stand in the house of the LORD, in the courts of the house of our God,
- 3 Praise the LORD; for the LORD is good: sing praises unto his name; for it is pleasant.
- 4 For the LORD hath chosen Jacob unto himself, and Israel for his peculiar treasure.
- 5 For I know that the LORD is great, and that our Lord is above all gods.
- 6 Whatsoever the LORD pleased, that did he in heaven, and in earth, in the seas, and all deep places.
- 7 He causeth the vapours to ascend from the ends of the earth; he maketh lightnings for the rain; he bringeth the wind out of his treasures.
- 8 Who smote the firstborn of Egypt, both of man and beast.
- 9 Who sent tokens and wonders into the midst of thee, O Egypt, upon Pharaoh, and upon all his servants.
- 10 Who smote great nations, and slew mighty kings;
- 11 Sihon king of the Amorites, and Og king of Bashan, and all the kingdoms of Canaan:
- 12 And gave their land for an heritage, an heritage unto Israel his people.
- 13 Thy name, O LORD, endureth for ever; and thy memorial, O LORD, throughout all generations.
- 14 For the LORD will judge his people, and he will repent himself concerning his servants.
- 15 The idols of the heathen are silver and gold, the work of men's hands.
- 16 They have mouths, but they speak not; eyes have they, but they see not;
- 17 They have ears, but they hear not; neither is there any breath in their mouths.
- 18 They that make them are like unto them: so is every one that trusteth in them.
- 19 Bless the LORD, O house of Israel: bless the LORD, O house of Aaron:
- 20 Bless the LORD, O house of Levi: ye that fear the LORD, bless the LORD.
- 21 Blessed be the LORD out of Zion, which dwelleth at Jerusalem. Praise ye the LORD.

2 · CONTEXT

Psalm 135 is a hallelujah psalm built almost entirely from earlier Scripture—echoing the exodus, the conquest, and the mockery of idols found elsewhere in the Psalter and the Prophets—woven into a single sustained call to worship. It moves from the temple courts outward to cosmic sovereignty, backward to historical deliverance, and then sharply contrasts the living God with the lifeless idols of the nations. Henry reads its density of reused language as intentional: praise here is disciplined recollection of what has already been revealed, not improvised novelty.

3 · VERSE-BY-VERSE COMMENTARY

The notes below cover the whole chapter in one place—read with the KJV text above.

Verse 1-4

Servants of the Lord standing in the temple courts are called to praise His name because it is good and pleasant to do so. The reason quickly becomes covenantal rather than generic: the Lord has chosen Jacob, chosen Israel, to be His own peculiar treasure.

Verse 5-7

Greatness is asserted in comparative terms—the Lord is above all so-called gods—and then demonstrated through sovereignty over nature itself: whatever pleases Him He does, in heaven, earth, and sea; He brings clouds from the ends of the earth, lightning with rain, and wind out of His storehouses. Weather itself becomes evidence of His unmatched authority.

Verse 8-12

Historical deliverance is recounted: the firstborn of Egypt struck down, signs and wonders sent against Pharaoh and his servants, many nations and mighty kings defeated—Sihon of the Amorites and Og of Bashan named specifically—and their land given as a heritage to Israel His people. Praise is anchored in remembered, concrete acts, not abstraction.

Verse 13-14

The Lord's name and memorial are declared to endure through every generation, alongside the assurance that He will judge His people and show compassion toward His servants—covenant loyalty proven reliable across time.

Verse 15-18

A sharp contrast follows: the idols of the nations are only silver and gold, the work of human hands, with mouths that cannot speak, eyes that cannot see, ears that cannot hear, and no breath in their mouths at all. Those who make and trust them are pronounced just as lifeless as what they worship.

Verse 19-21

The closing call widens to the whole worshipping community—house of Israel, house of Aaron, house of Levi, all who fear the Lord—summoned to bless the Lord who dwells in Jerusalem. Praise ends where it began, directed to the living God enthroned in Zion.

4 · MEANING & APPLICATION

Meaning.

True praise draws consciously on what God has already revealed—His sovereignty over creation, His concrete acts of deliverance, His enduring covenant loyalty—rather than floating free of specific content. The psalm's blunt satire of idols exposes the absurdity of worshipping anything less alive and responsive than the God who actually speaks, sees, hears, and acts in history.

Application for life today.

Build your own praise, as this psalm does, on specific remembered acts of God rather than only general sentiment—name particular deliverances from your own life alongside biblical history. Examine whether anything you currently trust functions like the idols of verses 15–18: something that cannot actually see, hear, or respond to you the way God can. Let the psalm's final widening call—every house, everyone who fears the Lord—prompt you to invite others into praise rather than keeping it solitary.

5 · REFLECT & RESPOND

Write your answers in the space below. There are no “right length” answers—honesty before God is the aim.

1. What specific, remembered act of God's deliverance in your own life could anchor your praise this week, following this psalm's pattern (vv. 8–12)?

2. Where might you be quietly trusting something as unresponsive as the idols described in verses 15–18—unable to truly see, hear, or help you?

3. How does the psalm's cosmic picture of God's sovereignty over weather and nations (vv. 5–7) enlarge your sense of what He is capable of in your own circumstances?

Name: _____ Date: _____ Group / Church: _____

Sources: King James Version (public domain); Matthew Henry, Commentary on the Whole Bible (themes summarized); Expository themes consistent with MacArthur Study Bible tradition (paraphrased, not quoted). Scripture: King James Version (public domain).